
Imagining a Realistic Scenario for First Contact

Now that we have covered the search for extraterrestrial intelligence in class, your group is equipped to imagine a realistic scenario for *first contact* with extraterrestrial life. While we don't know exactly how first contact would play out since we are pretty sure that it hasn't happened (..yet) your group should work to maintain scientific plausibility throughout your scenario.

As a starting point, you should assume that the contact is *not an invasion*. However, it is reasonable to assume that any alien intentions are unclear until the scenario plays out. Throughout the project, you should consider realistic factors like communication barriers (both physical and social) as well as social response (both general public as well as administrative/governmental).

Your group should develop the scenario together in detail and discuss how you will respond to each of the prompts below. Each team member should be assigned a contribution and your responses to each prompt should include a description of who contributed to that prompt.

Your responses should be gathered into a single document (Google Docs is a good starting point for this!) for submission to Canvas. Only one submission per group is necessary.

Describing Your *First Contact* Scenario

Describe your first contact scenario in 3-5 paragraphs. Your description should address the following:

- How does first contact occur? (e.g., a distant radio signal, a robotic probe, or a physical arrival)
- Where does it take place? (Earth, orbit, deep space, somewhere else?)
- Who is involved first? (Scientists, military, governments, media, the public, someone else?)
- How does society respond? (Do governments decide to reveal or conceal the information? What actions do they take? What about other institutions like universities or corporations?)
- What challenges arise in communication and understanding (both with the aliens as well as within our broader society)?

A Detailed Window Into Society's Response Choose one of the following formats to imagine how your scenario might play out in more detail:

- **Government Briefing Memo:** Write a classified memo advising world leaders on how to respond.

- **News Report:** Create a 300-word breaking news article covering the first 24 hours of contact.
- **Dialogue Scene:** Write a 1-2 page script of a government official speaking with an alien entity.
- **Social Media Thread:** Simulate public reaction with 10 social media posts.

Reflection Address the following questions in a paragraph for each point to reflect on your scenario:

- What considerations did you take to make your scenario as realistic as possible?
- What are the largest challenges that would arise in your first contact scenario? How does this differ from other scenarios (e.g. if yours is on Earth, how might different challenges arise in a different setting)?
- How might governments and the public react differently to your scenario?